Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH



"FEEDERS AND RESCUERS NOW HAVE AN EMPOWERMENT THEY DIDN'T BEFORE. WE ALSO GET A LOT OF SUPPORT FROM THE YOUNGER GENERATION"
– CHARU KHOSLA
CAT CAFE, Mumbai

a brand that can demonstrate care and consideration for pets through its work and products," he says. The company, through its foundation, also runs educational programmes at public schools across the country to teach children how to share space with and respect all street animals. They also prepare food for street dogs and have fed 1-1.5 million dogs to date through partnerships with various charities."

Running a business and a charity at the same time is not always easy, though. "It is not a business like in Japan where people come just to play with cats," says Charu Khosla, co-owner of the Cat Café in Mumbai, which is also the adoption implementation partner of the NGO The Feline Foundation. Customers at the café can buy Maggi and lemonade and also enjoy the company of some 20-25 street cats—with an entry fee of Rs 200 for cat area—looking for a forever home. "We keep rescue cats who cannot be released back to the streets as they are disabled or are in need of care intervention," says Khosla. "It isn't easy to run it, but I see signs of change—feeders and rescuers now have an empowerment they didn't have before. We also get a lot of support from the younger generation."

BEST PAW FORWARD Lovely, a King Charles Spaniel, gets groomed at her house in Flying Fur's mobile pet spa, Delhi

Never has the demand for pets and pet-specific products and services been higher, say industry experts. Many a human says they would rather have a pet than a child. Social media abounds with reels and feeds of dogs and cats being lavished upon by their humans—hand fed gourmet food, bathed in ayurvedic oils, dressed in silk gowns and tucked into bed alongside human babies. Keeping a pet is serious business, and no one knows it better than pet businesses. ■

– *with* Suhani Singh